PRODUCT STRATEGY ASSIGNMENT

Sample solution for evaluator calibration

Product: Google Maps
Proposed feature: Commute Confidence
Focus: Helping urban commuters choose a reliable route—not just the fastest route.

Assignment brief

Choose a digital product or feature with room for improvement. Analyze its users and competitive context, define a meaningful problem, propose a product solution, map the journey and requirements, and outline a launch plan with risks.

Evaluation note: This is a fictional proposal for testing an evaluation rubric. Competitor observations are high-level public-positioning summaries; user findings, targets, and expected impact are hypotheses that a real team would validate with research and product data.

1. Executive summary

Opportunity. Commuters often need a dependable arrival time more than the absolute fastest route. Standard navigation ETAs can change during a trip, while users may not know whether a route is volatile, what caused a delay, or when they should leave to arrive on time.

Proposal: Commute Confidence. Add an optional commute-planning layer in Google Maps that shows an arrival-time range, a confidence indicator, and a simple explanation of route volatility. Users can set an arrival deadline and receive a recommended departure window, with privacy-conscious alerts when the estimate changes materially.

Value proposition. “Know when to leave—and how confident you can be that you’ll arrive on time.” This complements existing route guidance instead of replacing it.

WHO	WHAT HURTS	PROPOSED VALUE	HOW WE MEASURE
Regular urban commuters with fixed arrival times	Uncertainty, last-minute route changes, and fear of being late	A clearer arrival range and useful departure guidance	On-time arrival rate, ETA stability, weekly feature retention

Recommendation

Run a limited pilot in one or two cities and compare the feature against the current experience. Do not promise a guaranteed arrival time; communicate uncertainty honestly and keep the feature optional.

2. Market and competitor analysis

Target personas

Persona	Context and need	Pain points	Success looks like
Primary: Routine commuter Age 22–45; travels to work or university 4–6 days/week	Has a recurring destination and a meaningful arrival deadline	ETA swings; uncertain buffer time; checks several times before leaving	Leaves at the right time and arrives reliably with fewer checks
Secondary: Caregiver / appointment traveler	Travels to school pickup, medical visits, or scheduled appointments	Late arrival has a high personal cost; unfamiliar with local traffic patterns	Receives a useful buffer and clear explanation when risk rises
Secondary: Flexible commuter	Can shift departure by 10–30 minutes	Cannot easily tell whether leaving later will materially increase risk	Chooses a better departure window without excessive notifications

Market trends and context

• Navigation is increasingly expected to be predictive and personalized, not only a turn-by-turn map.

• Users are familiar with live traffic and ETAs, so a new feature must add decision value rather than duplicate traffic colors.

• Privacy expectations matter: location history is sensitive, and commute insights should be opt-in, explainable, and easy to disable.

• A credible differentiator is trust: communicating uncertainty clearly may be more useful than displaying a falsely precise single ETA.

These are strategic hypotheses, not quantified market claims. A real submission should validate them through interviews, search trends, competitor testing, and existing product analytics.

Competitor landscape

Product	Strength / current user expectation	Potential gap this proposal targets
Google Maps	Broad place discovery, route alternatives, traffic-aware navigation, and a large user base	A dedicated, easy-to-understand view of arrival reliability and departure planning may be less prominent than route selection
Waze	Community-reported incidents and a driving-focused, real-time traffic experience	Incident awareness is useful, but users may still want a calm, personal arrival-confidence summary and deadline-based departure guidance
Apple Maps	Integrated navigation experience for Apple-device users, with traffic and route guidance	An opportunity exists to compete on transparent arrival ranges and explainable confidence, rather than feature parity alone

Competitive interpretation

The proposal does not claim that competitors lack traffic estimates or commute features. The hypothesized gap is the combination of (1) arrival-time range, (2) confidence explanation, and (3) a practical departure recommendation in one low-friction workflow. The team should mystery-shop each product before finalizing positioning.

3. Product strategy and vision

Problem statement

For urban commuters who must arrive at a specific time, current navigation experiences provide route and ETA information but may not make arrival uncertainty actionable. This can cause late arrivals, unnecessary early departures, and repeated checking. The problem matters because users make the leave-now-or-wait decision every day, and trust is damaged when an ETA changes without a clear explanation.

Why now?

• Users already expect real-time traffic-aware ETAs; the next step is helping them make a decision with uncertainty.

• Better historical travel patterns and live traffic signals may support more useful estimates, subject to data quality and local coverage.

• Reliability is a differentiated user outcome: a route that is nominally faster is not always the route a deadline-sensitive user prefers.

Vision and value proposition

Vision: Make every commute feel more predictable.
Value proposition: Plan around the arrival time you need, understand the risk of delay, and receive only meaningful updates.

Solution concept: Commute Confidence

Capability	User experience	Why it matters
Arrival range	Show an estimated range such as 8:35–8:45, not only a single point estimate.	Makes uncertainty visible without implying a guarantee.
Confidence label	Use simple labels such as Higher / Moderate / Lower confidence with a short reason.	Helps users interpret the estimate quickly.
Leave-by guidance	User sets desired arrival time; Maps suggests a departure time and optional buffer.	Turns information into a decision.
Material-change alert	Notify only when predicted arrival or risk changes beyond a threshold.	Reduces repeated checking and notification fatigue.
Explainability	Examples: “Heavy traffic on your usual route” or “Limited recent data for this trip.”	Builds trust and communicates limitations.

Scope and non-goals

• **In scope for MVP:** saved commute, arrival deadline, range/confidence, leave-by recommendation, material-change alert, settings and feedback.

• **Out of scope:** guaranteed arrival, autonomous route changes without consent, social commute sharing, complex multi-stop planning, and a new traffic prediction engine built from scratch.

Success metrics: proposed pilot targets

Metric	Definition	Illustrative target	Guardrail
Primary: on-time arrival rate	Share of opted-in commute trips arriving by the user-set deadline, measured only where timing data is available and consented	+5 percentage points vs. control after 8 weeks	Do not claim causality without controlled comparison
ETA stability	Median absolute change in predicted arrival during the final 30 minutes before departure	10% relative improvement vs. control	Do not hide genuine incidents to stabilize ETA

Metric	Definition	Illustrative target	Guardrail
Feature retention	Share of pilot users using the feature in week 4	30% weekly active use among eligible opt-ins	Segment by commute frequency and city
Notification quality	Helpful rating and opt-out / disable rate	≥70% helpful; no meaningful rise in opt-outs	Monitor notification fatigue

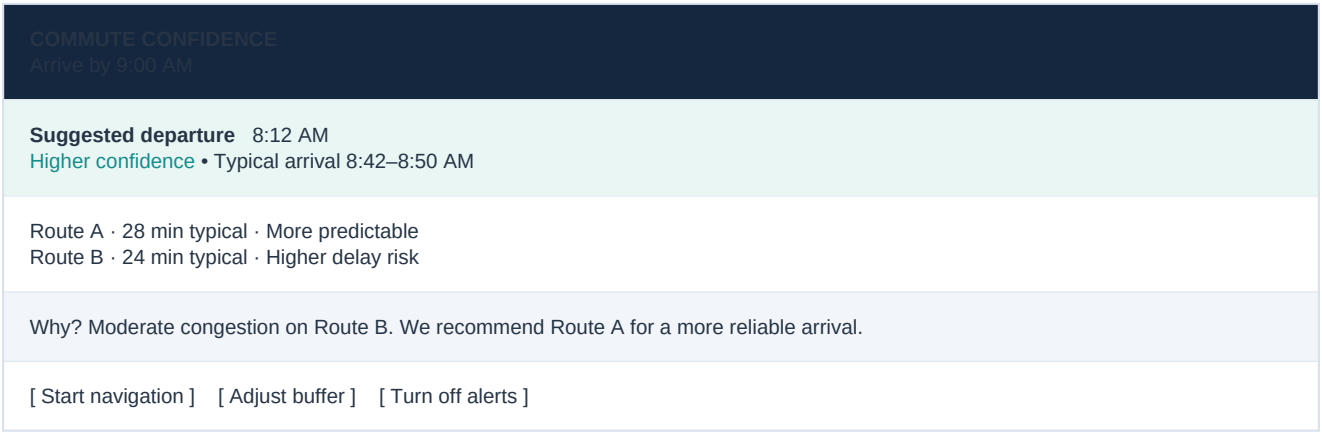
Targets are examples for a test assignment, not forecasts or commitments. Baselines and sample size should be established before the pilot.

4. Product design and user journey

Key workflow

Step	User action	Product response	Success condition
1. Set up	Save a frequent destination and select “Arrive by”.	Explain what commute data is used and ask for opt-in.	User understands the feature and consents.
2. Plan	Choose arrival time and buffer preference.	Show route options, arrival range, confidence and suggested leave-by time.	User can compare options and decide.
3. Travel	Start navigation or dismiss the recommendation.	Monitor material changes; avoid noisy updates.	Updates are timely and relevant.
4. Review	Rate whether the estimate was helpful.	Ask one lightweight feedback question; provide settings control.	Feedback informs calibration and user can opt out.

Low-fidelity wireframe (concept)



Illustrative interface only. In the actual product, route and timing values would come from Maps systems; the sample numbers above are placeholders.

MVP requirements (PRD-style)

ID / priority	User story and requirement	Acceptance criteria
R1 · P0	As a commuter, I want to set an arrival deadline so I can plan when to leave.	Deadline and buffer are editable; feature explains that estimates are not guarantees.
R2 · P0	As a commuter, I want an arrival range and confidence label so I can judge reliability.	Range is shown only when data quality meets a minimum threshold; otherwise show a clear fallback.
R3 · P0	As a commuter, I want a leave-by recommendation that accounts for my buffer.	Recommendation updates when material inputs change; no silent change to a chosen route.
R4 · P1	As a commuter, I want alerts only when my arrival risk changes meaningfully.	User can control alerts; deduplicate repeated events and provide quiet/disable controls.
R5 · P1	As a user, I want to know why confidence changed.	Provide a short reason and do not imply certainty when data is sparse.
R6 · P1	As a user, I want to disable the feature and manage data use.	Opt-out is discoverable; location/data settings follow existing Maps controls and policy.

Prioritization and trade-offs

• **P0:** Deadline, range/confidence, leave-by guidance, minimum-data safeguards. These form the core value proposition.

• **P1:** Alerts, explanations, feedback. Valuable, but can follow after the base recommendation is trustworthy.

• **Trade-off:** A range is less visually simple than one ETA, but more honest about uncertainty. Use progressive disclosure so the main screen stays uncluttered.

• **Trade-off:** More personalization may improve estimates but increases privacy and complexity costs. Start with explicit opt-in and transparent controls.

5. Go-to-market, experimentation and risks

Launch plan

Phase	Timing	Activities	Exit criteria
1. Discovery	Weeks 1–3	Interview 12–15 commuters across routine and deadline-sensitive segments; test current Maps/Waze/Apple Maps workflows; audit ETA volatility data.	Repeated pain is validated; users understand range and confidence concepts.
2. Prototype	Weeks 4–6	Usability-test 2–3 interface variants; test confidence wording, range display, and alert thresholds.	Users can explain the recommendation and distinguish estimate from guarantee.
3. Controlled pilot	Weeks 7–12	Roll out to a small opted-in cohort in one or two cities; use a holdout/control where feasible; monitor quality and opt-outs.	Primary metric improves without violating guardrails.
4. Iterate / scale	After pilot	Fix calibration issues, refine segments and alert rules, then expand gradually.	Reliable results across different commute patterns and data conditions.

Positioning and distribution

• **Positioning:** “Plan your arrival, not just your route.”

• **Discovery:** Optional prompt after a user repeatedly navigates to the same destination at similar times; avoid interrupting first-time users.

• **Activation:** A short setup flow—save destination, choose arrival time, set buffer, opt in to alerts.

• **Education:** A brief tooltip clarifies that confidence reflects available data and is not a guarantee.

• **Growth loop:** Helpful arrival outcomes and lightweight feedback improve calibration; do not use social sharing as a launch dependency.

Risks and mitigations

Risk	Impact	Mitigation / edge case
False confidence	Users trust a high-confidence estimate and arrive late.	Calibrate labels against observed error; display ranges; suppress confidence when data is weak; never guarantee arrival.
Sparse or unusual data	New routes, road closures, severe weather, holidays or special events degrade predictions.	Fallback to standard ETA; state why confidence is limited; test across conditions and locations.
Notification fatigue	Users mute alerts or abandon the feature.	Use material-change thresholds, deduplicate alerts, allow quiet hours and instant opt-out.
Privacy concern	Users reject opt-in or feel tracked.	Collect only necessary signals; explain data use; honor existing controls and retention policies; make opt-in reversible.
Equity / coverage gap	Feature works better in data-rich areas than underserved areas.	Audit performance by area and travel mode; do not present unequal data quality as equal confidence.
Metric gaming	A stable ETA could be achieved by delaying updates rather than improving predictions.	Pair stability with arrival accuracy, user helpfulness and incident responsiveness guardrails.

Decision framework

Proceed to broader launch only if the pilot improves on-time arrival or another pre-registered primary outcome, users understand the uncertainty display, and guardrails remain healthy. If reliability gains are not demonstrated, revise the prediction approach or reposition the feature as planning assistance rather than confidence scoring.

6. Evaluation rubric alignment

This sample is designed to demonstrate the four areas in the provided evaluation form. The score should reflect evidence and clarity in the submitted work, not simply whether the evaluator agrees with the idea.

Area / weight	Evidence in this sample	What a strong evaluator should look for
1. Strategic Thinking & Market Insight 25%	Personas, trends, competitor comparison, hypothesized market gap, and why now.	Specific target users; credible competitive framing; gap is differentiated and validated or clearly labeled as a hypothesis.
2. Problem Solving & Product Vision 25%	Problem statement, vision, value proposition, solution scope, KPIs and guardrails.	Clear problem-to-solution logic; meaningful prioritization; measurable outcomes rather than feature lists alone.
3. Execution & Requirements Quality 30%	User journey, wireframe, P0/P1 requirements, acceptance criteria, trade-offs, launch phases and risks.	Workflows are coherent; requirements are testable; edge cases and dependencies are considered; scope is realistic.
4. Communication & Presentation 20%	Structured sections, concise tables, clear terminology, explicit assumptions and decision criteria.	Easy to scan; logical narrative; no unsupported certainty; recommendations and metrics are understandable.

Illustrative scoring example

For evaluator calibration only, this sample could be scored as follows if the evaluator values clear structure and product logic but expects primary research and stronger evidence before awarding top marks:

Area	Weight	Illustrative rating / 5	Weighted points / 100	Reason
Strategic Thinking & Market Insight	25%	3.5 / 5	17.5	Good framing; market gap remains a hypothesis.
Problem Solving & Product Vision	25%	4.0 / 5	20.0	Clear problem, coherent solution and metrics.
Execution & Requirements Quality	30%	4.0 / 5	24.0	Useful journey and testable requirements; feasibility needs validation.
Communication & Presentation	20%	4.5 / 5	18.0	Clear structure and scannable presentation.
Total	**100%**		**79.5 / 100**	Illustrative only—not an objective or official score.

Scoring method: weighted points = (rating ÷ 5) × area weight. For example, a 4/5 in a 25%-weighted area earns 20 points out of 100.

How to improve this sample into a top-tier submission

• Add 5–8 short interview findings or usability-test observations and distinguish evidence from assumptions.

• Include a competitor feature audit with dated observations and direct links to official product documentation.

• Define the primary metric precisely, identify the control group, and estimate sample size before the experiment.

• Add accessibility considerations, data-quality thresholds, and localization for markets with different road-data coverage.

• Show one more detailed flow for an exception case: low confidence, route closure, no network, or a changed arrival deadline.

Conclusion

Commute Confidence is a focused enhancement to a familiar product: it reframes navigation around dependable arrival planning. The strongest reason to test it is a specific user decision—when to leave—not novelty for its own sake. Its success depends on trustworthy estimates, transparent uncertainty, privacy-conscious design, and a pilot that proves user outcomes improve.

Assumptions and limitations: This document is a sample assignment for test/evaluation use. It is not affiliated with Google. Competitor descriptions are intentionally high-level, and all targets, wireframe values, and score estimates are illustrative. Verify current feature details and gather primary research before using this as a real product recommendation.